

Naomi picked up her purse off the floor in anticipation of leaving. She and Ben hadn't discussed the cost of bankruptcy or much of anything else. The financial pressure on their marriage was killing their communication. She slid to the front of her seat, ready to get up and leave, certain that Ben would do the same. She knew her parents wouldn't loan them the money for bankruptcy, and chances were that his parents wouldn't, either. She held out her hand to the attorney. "Joe, thanks so much for trying to help us. Looks like we're out of options."

"Well ... not exactly," Ben said. "My parents have agreed to cover the cost."

Naomi shot an angry look at her husband. Once again, he had failed to communicate. "Ben, if you're talking about another loan, I'm not for it."

"Not this time." He reached out and put his hand on hers. "We don't have to pay them back. Dad and Mom want us to have a fresh start. I've assured them that we're going to get a grip on our spending."

"How long have you known this?"

"Dad called me on my cell phone last week when I was at work. I was going to tell you, but then I got busy and forgot. You know how it goes."

*No, I don't know how it goes!* Naomi thought as Ben gave her another reminder of his carelessness. She wanted to give him a piece of her mind, but not in front of the attorney. "I wish you'd told me," she said. "When you do things like this, I feel completely left out."

"I'm sorry, honey," Ben replied. "Right now, I'm stressed ... we both are. But after this bankruptcy goes through, things are going to get better."

"You're going to see a big difference," Joe interjected. "And I think it was a wise decision for your parents to help, Ben. With your commitment to get control of your spending and pay what the court requires, you're going to get back on your feet and get a new start